Why people leave

Cestária Supermercados · Separations and exit interviews, 2024 and 2025

Felipe Fonseca · Orbita Space · October 27, 2026

The stated reason is not always the real one: among those who rated their manager 1 or 2, leadership and manager is the reason for 45% of voluntary exits, and pay, for 21%.

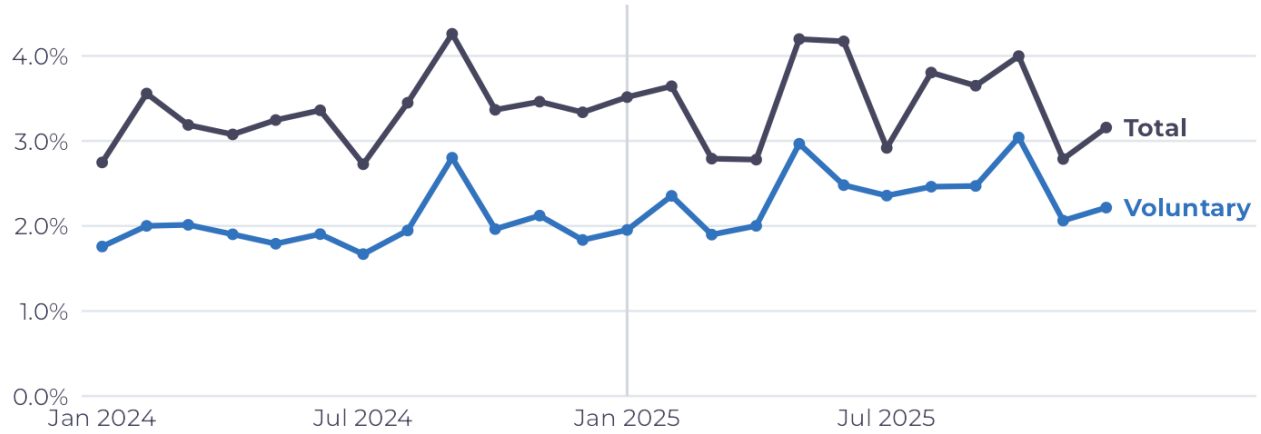
1. Summary

The Cestária separation rate held steady: 3.31% of the workforce left each month in 2024 and 3.45% in 2025. Leadership asked why people resign and where to act first.

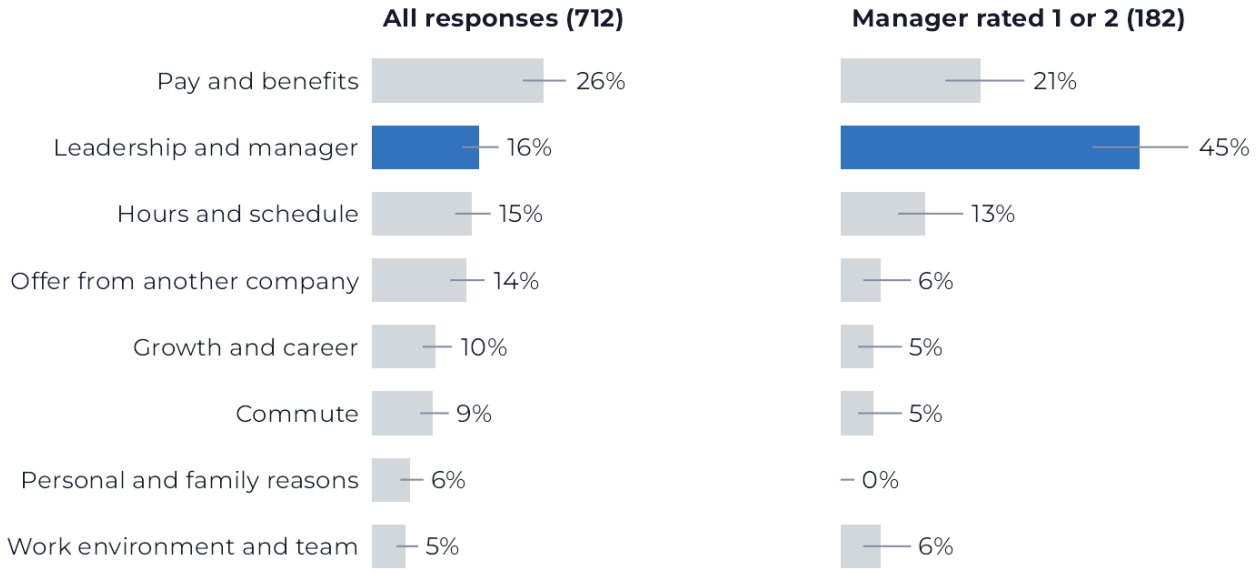
- **The stated reason hides the real one.** "Pay and benefits" is the reason most often given (26%), but, among those who rated their manager 1 or 2, "leadership and manager" moves ahead: 45% against 21%.
- **Exits in the first 90 days grew in two departments:** in DC Shipping, from 20% to 39% of new hires; in L3 Operations, from 20% to 41%.
- **L5 Sales has been losing more people since its manager changed**, in July 2025: its rate was 2.5 times what the other Sales departments would predict.
- **The night 6x1 schedule (six days on, one day off) concentrates "hours and schedule"**, the reason for 40% of exits there, against 8% everywhere else.
- **Age does not explain the exits:** the effect disappears once tenure enters the model.

2. The question

Cestária has 8 stores, a distribution center (DC) and a headquarters office (HQ), and about 1,790 people. In 2024 and 2025, 1,453 people left. The total barely changed, a difference consistent with chance ($p = .45$), but voluntary exits rose from 1.98% to 2.35% a month, and dismissals fell by almost the same amount. To answer leadership, the exit interview was crossed with the monthly headcount and the separations.



3. What the stated reason hides



There were 712 responses from people who resigned (resignation or mutual agreement). Overall, pay leads, at 25.6% (95% CI 22.5% to 28.9%). Among the 182 people who rated their manager 1 or 2, "leadership and manager" rises to 44.5% (37.5% to 51.8%). Of the 38 people with a low rating who gave pay as their reason, 58% gave leadership as their secondary reason.

This does not prove that the manager caused the exit. It shows that the main reason, read on its own, points to pay, while the rating and the second reason point to leadership.

3.1. Who answered

Of those who resigned, 77% answered, against 38% of those who were dismissed; L7 came in at 37%. The reason is only asked of people who resign; the gap between sites was corrected by weighting each response by the inverse of its site's response rate. No reason moved by more than 0.3 percentage point, and the order stayed the same. The weighting assumes that, within each site, the people who answered are similar to those who did not.

Reason	Unweighted	Weighted
Pay and benefits	25.6%	25.6%
Leadership and manager	16.0%	15.9%
Hours and schedule	14.9%	14.9%
Offer from another company	14.0%	14.0%
Growth and career	9.6%	9.4%
Commute	9.1%	8.9%
Personal and family reasons	5.8%	6.0%
Work environment and team	5.1%	5.2%

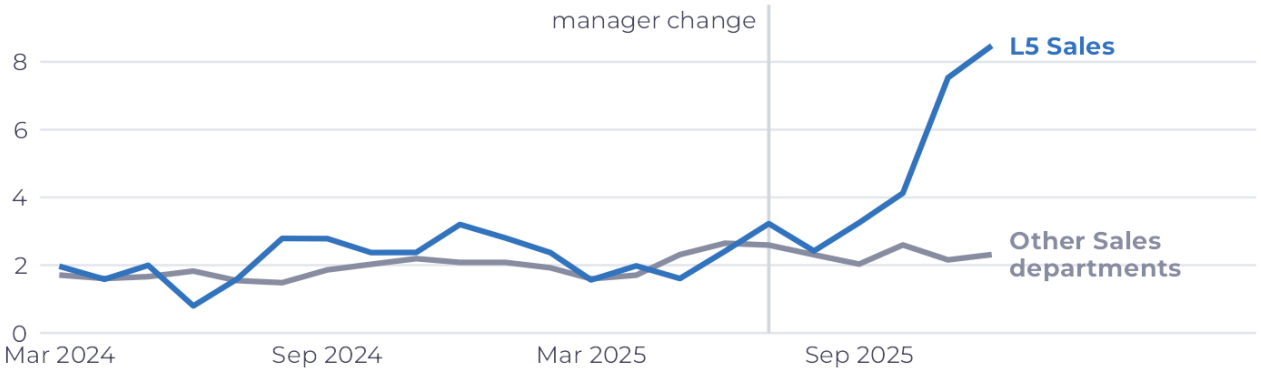
4. Where to act first

4.1. Exits in the first 90 days



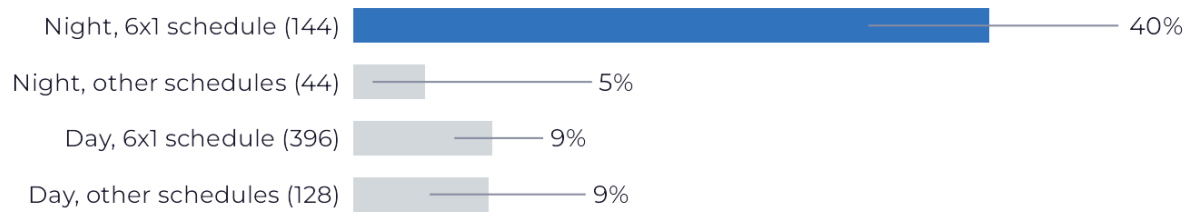
Among people hired up to October 2, 2025, the share who resigned within 90 days went, in DC Shipping, from 20% (2024 hires) to 39% (2025 hires), and in L3 Operations, from 20% to 41%; in the others, from 15% to 17%. In 2025, the risk was 2.2 and 2.1 times that of the other departments (cause-specific Cox). The chart shows cumulative incidence, with all hires and dismissal as a competing risk; that is why, at 90 days, it does not exactly match these proportions.

4.2. The manager change in L5 Sales



Before the change, L5 lost 2.1% of its staff a month to voluntary exits; afterward, 5.8%. The other Sales departments went from 2.0% to 2.2%. Netting that out, the L5 rate was 2.5 times higher (95% CI 1.4 to 4.4). “Leadership and manager” went from fewer than 10 of the 25 responses to 17 of 24. It is an association in time, with only six months of data after the change.

4.3. The 6x1 schedule on the night shift



“Hours and schedule” is the reason for 40% of voluntary exits on the night 6x1 schedule (33% to 48%), against 8% in the other combinations. Night work on other schedules does not have the same problem: what weighs is the single day off a week.

5. Priorities by department

For 2025. **High:** the voluntary rate or exits within 90 days are above the company (2.35% a month and 24%) even at the lower bound of the 95% interval. **Medium:** both above in the point estimate, or a reason (leadership, schedule) above the company at the lower bound. The other departments are at “Monitor” and are in the CSV, with the intervals; no group of fewer than 10 people appears. L2 Operations stands out for “hours and schedule” in the reason by department cross-tab, but stays at “Monitor”: in 2025, its voluntary rate (2.82% a month) is above the company (2.35%) only in the point estimate, its exits within 90 days (6%) are below the company (24%), and the share of “hours and schedule” among its 2025 responses does not exceed the company at the lower bound of the interval.

	Department	Priority	Signals	Vol. rate/month	Within 90 days	Leadership
1	DC Shipping	High	Voluntary rate; Exits within 90 days	3.21%	39%	16%
2	L5 Sales	High	Voluntary rate; Leadership and manager	3.85%	25%	55%
3	L3 Operations	High	Exits within 90 days	2.84%	41%	8%
4	L1 Operations	Medium	Voluntary rate (point estimate); Exits within 90 days (point estimate)	3.60%	30%	6%

6. What to do

- **DC Shipping and L3 Operations:** listen to new hires before 90 days and review onboarding and the schedule described at hiring.
- **L5 Sales:** a structured conversation with the team and with the new manager, and monthly tracking of the rate against the other stores.
- **Night 6x1 schedule:** study another schedule for night restocking, starting with the departments with the most exits.
- **Interview:** always ask for the secondary reason and the manager rating, and seek more responses at L7.

7. Limitations

- Fictional data: the patterns were planted by a generator, and the analysis found them without reading the answer key.
- Response bias: the weighting only corrects the gap between sites.
- Association is not causation: the L5 comparison assumes it would have followed the trend of the other Sales departments without the change.
- The reason is self-reported, from a closed list; people hired after October 2, 2025 fall outside the 90-day window.

The full method, the regressions and the R code are on the case page, at orbitaspace.com.br/en/projects/turnover-exit-reasons.